

Family as a System

A systemic approach to
understanding family

System = a unit where its parts interact with and mutually influence each other

History and Origin

- **General systems theory** (Ludwig von Bertalanffy)
 - **Context:** First developed during World War 2 / more sophisticated weapons were needed in combat with enemy forces
 - (Eg.) Radar system operates by certain processes that keep it functioning, based on the science of *cybernetics*
 - *Later applied to biology and family*



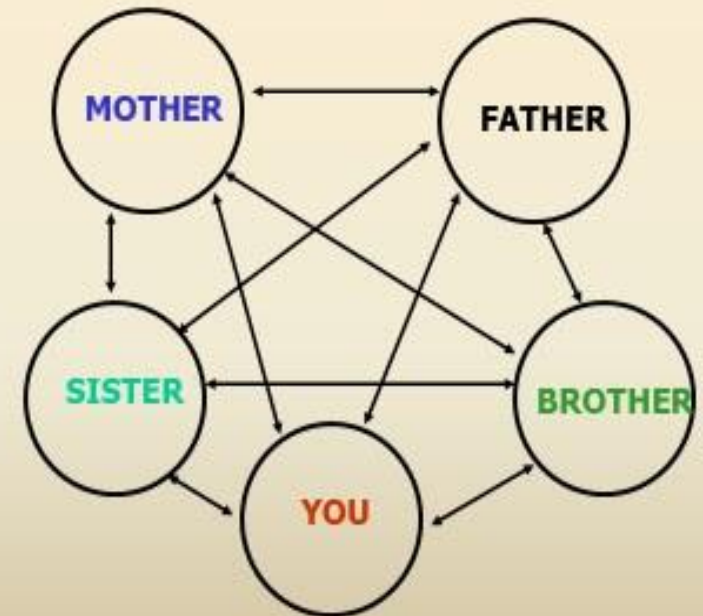
Emergence of Family Systems Theory

- Following the War, psychiatrists and sociologists who studied families began to think about families as systems.
- (A major SHIFT!) An individual- and biology-centered explanation for Schizophrenia → the influence of family on the person's mental symptoms
- The application of GST to family science had begun!

A Systems View of Families

- **Family systems theory** views family as a complex system comprised of interrelated parts, each influencing one another
- Family is a system consisting of *interdependent* individuals who:
 - Share sense of history with each other
 - Have emotional bonding with each other
 - Interact with one another
 - Influence one another
- Cannot understand any part of the system without looking at the whole picture → **Holism**

THE FAMILY SYSTEM



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What do we need to understand a family?

- Two families live on the 3rd floor next to each other in the same apartment complex
- In both families, a married couple and a 15-year-old teenage daughter live together. And their daughter is depressed.
- Can we say these two families are identical or similar?
- What kind of information would you need in order to understand and learn about each family?

Some questions that can help us understand a family

- Composition
 - Membership (who's in it?)
- What's their sociocultural background?
 - Where are they from? (e.g., cultural/ethnic origin, hometown, etc.)
 - Where do they work?
 - What's their education level?
- What goes on inside each family
 - How does each member interact with one another in each family?
 - Any rules in the family?
 - How are the roles and responsibilities divided and assigned?
 - Particular strategies used to accomplish family tasks
- What was their upbringing like? Family of origin?
- And many more...

A method of collecting information

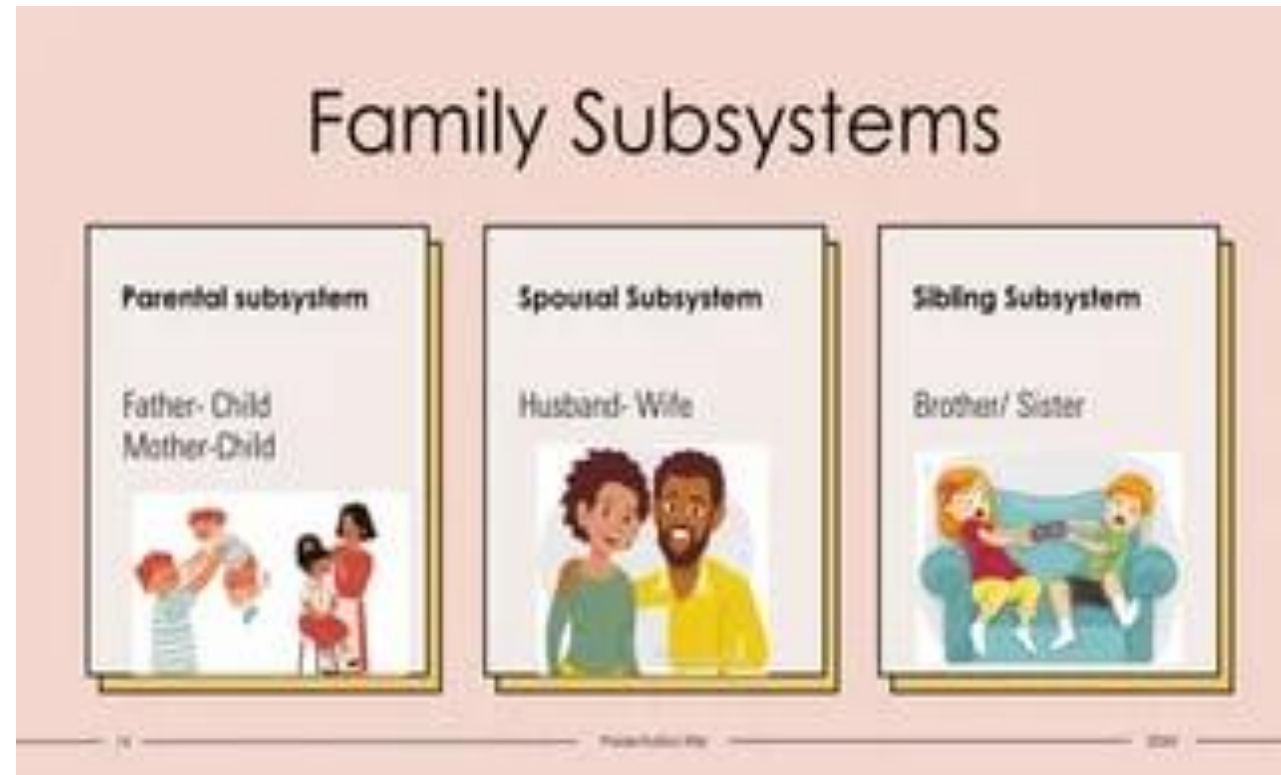
- 1) interview each family member// WHY?
 - Only a single person's perspective
 - Individuals cannot be understood in isolation from one another, but rather as a part of their **family**
 - Most of the time, individual problems are rooted in their family
- 2) interview and/or observe all of them together
 - An effective way to identify interactional patterns in the family
- 3) do both

Wholeness

- The family is not simply all of its members added together (→ only composition: e.g., two-parent family, four-member family, etc.)
- Each family has a unique personality that is different from the combination of each of its members because of unique patterns of how they interact with each other
- "The whole is greater than the sum of its parts."

Subsystem

- A family system is comprised of smaller units, called "subsystem"
- **Example:**
 - Marital, parent-child and sibling subsystems
- Different interactional patterns exist in each subsystem
- Each subsystem usually play a unique role.



Subsystem

- Family system also a subsystem within the broader community and society
 - The social, political, economic, educational, and ethical agendas of these broader social systems have an impact on the family

Interdependence

- A change in one family member affects—and is affected by—the responses of other members.
- Factors that appear to influence only one person have an impact on everyone.
 - Aging
 - Pregnancy
 - Illness
 - And many more....

Feedback Loop

- explains how family members influence one another in ongoing cycles of interaction
- describe how patterns are **maintained, reinforced, or changed**.

Positive Feedback Loop

change and escalation

- Responses that amplify change, pushing the system toward a new pattern.
- Parent criticizes → child withdraws → parent criticizes more → child withdraws further.
- it means **change is reinforced**, sometimes escalating into conflict or crisis, other times leading to growth.

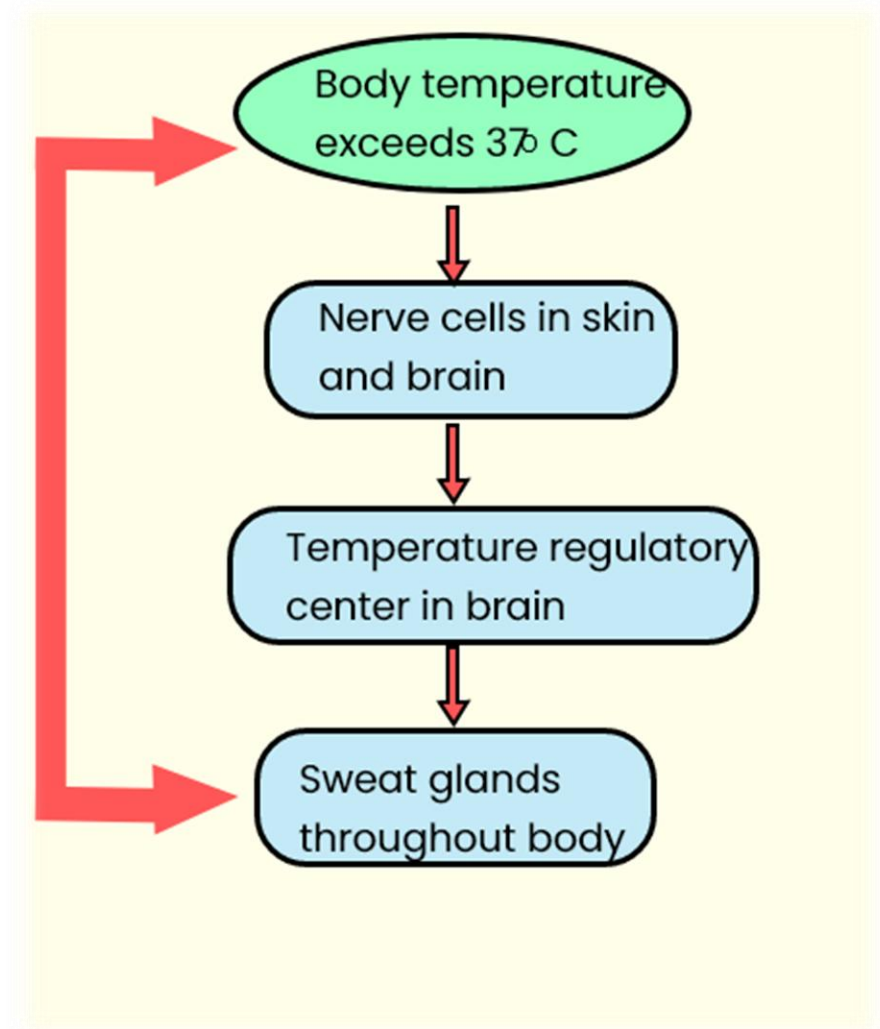
Negative Feedback Loop

Stability, homeostasis

- Corrective responses that reduce change and bring the system back to balance.
- A teenager pushes against curfew. Parents tighten rules → teen backs down → balance restored.
- it's about **maintaining the status quo**.

Homeostasis

- the tendency within family systems to maintain the status quo or to stay the same
- often only altered by a major life event such as death, or an outside force, such as a romantic partner or a therapist.
- family members tend to make choices that serve to maintain, rather than modify, their present family role.



Boundaries

- psychological and relational “lines” within and around family
- the set of usually unspoken rules that regulates contact among family members and subsystems
- E.g.,) who participates in an interaction, what roles they have, how close or separate they are, and how much information or emotion crosses between them

(1) Internal Boundary

- Boundaries that organize relationships within the family (such as parent–child, couple, and sibling subsystems)

(2) External Boundary

- Boundaries around family marking the limits of a system
- between the family and people outside it.

Boundary (Internal)

- **Internal boundaries:**
 - How relational distance between individuals and subsystems are regulated and managed within families
 - To what degree is **individuality** and **autonomy** encouraged or tolerated?
 - *Parents who share adult worries with their children (diffuse)*
 - *Siblings who rarely interact with each other (rigid)*
 - How much **intimacy** vs. **privacy and independence** is allowed for each family member and within family

Boundary (External)

- **External boundaries**
 - Membership
 - Rules established for interacting with outsiders
- How families maintain their integrity, cohesiveness, and separateness in relation to the external environment
 - Extended family constantly intruding in family decision-making? (diffuse/rigid)

Boundary (External)

- **Open/diffuse external boundaries (high permeability):**
 - Home is open to others
 - Ex: neighbors are free to drop in for dinner
 - (example) My father-in-law who lives alone has a lot of say in every affair of my children's education.
 - Information from the family can flow easily to outside systems

Boundary (External)

- **Closed/rigid external boundaries: (Low permeability)**
 - The home is relatively closed to outsiders.
 - Ex: children can not have friends come over for slumber party.
 - Heavy emphasis on family privacy.
 - Information is kept in the home.
 - Physical home is structured in a closed and private way.
 - Not open to outside intervention (e.g., family therapy)

We are very careful about **who our children play with**-we want to know their families.

We restrict the amount and **type of television shows** the children can watch as well as the movies they see.

In all of this I see we are strengthening our boundaries to make sure that **information we do not approve of** can't pass through, and things that fit with our values do make it through.

We are kind of like **gatekeepers** for our kids.

Jackson's Family: Case Study

- Jackson, a 12-year-old boy, had lived with his mother until she remarried her boyfriend of two years. Jackson and his mother had been like bestfriends to each other. About six months after the marriage, Jackson's school contacted his mother with concerns: his classroom behavior and academic performance had declined sharply, and he had begun getting into frequent conflicts with peers.
- At home, Jackson's mother had also noticed that he had become increasingly argumentative with his stepfather. He was no longer communicating openly with her and appeared more withdrawn. She wondered whether these changes were simply signs that he was entering adolescence. Because she was already concerned about his behavior, she thought it might be helpful for Jackson to receive individual counseling.
- However, the school counselor suggested that the entire family attend counseling together. Jackson's mother was surprised and somewhat shocked by this recommendation. She wondered, "Is it really necessary for all of us to go to counseling? Why can't Jackson just receive counseling on his own?"

Jackson's Family: Case Study

Q1. Why was Jackson's mom so shocked that the counselor wanted to see the *whole* family? What did that invitation seem to imply to her? If you were the school counselor, how would you explain the rationale for family sessions in one or two sentences?

Q2. "Jackson has a behavior problem" vs. "this family is reorganizing after a remarriage" — how would each framing change what the counselor asks about, and who gets labeled as the problem?

Q3. When the stepfather joined, what changed in the family's **boundaries and subsystems**? Give one example of a **feedback loop** connecting Jackson, his mother, and his stepfather.